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CHARLES REZNIKOFF

Q. Mr. Reznikoff, could you start with a few comments about your participation in the so-called objectivist group and perhaps draw some conclusions about what “objectivism” was?

A. Yes, let me start by reading something I ran into only a few days ago, from a book of late T’ang poetry. Right in the beginning there’s a quotation or translation from something written a thousand years ago. I suppose I oughtn’t go back that far, but, like a lot of people, I like to find ancient authority. The introduction is by a man named A. C. Graham and he begins by quoting the remarks of a Chinese poet of the eleventh century. This is his translation: “Poetry presents the thing in order to convey the feeling. It should be precise about the thing and reticent about the feeling.” And further on, commenting on another poet, Mr. Graham says, “A rigor in seeking the objective correlative of emotion is a strong point of most Chinese poetry of all periods.” I thought that these comments, particularly the first, are a very accurate expression of what the objectivists were trying to do. Of course, the feeling is there in the selection of the material; you pick certain things that are significant—that’s your feeling. You don’t go into the feeling; you portray it as well as you can, hoping that somebody else reading the poem will get your feeling. Now, as part of that, I should perhaps say that I try to be as clear and precise as possible. I think that’s the very word that was used in the translation of the Chinese poet: “precise.” It’s perhaps a far cry from what the symbolists meant when they said, “To name is to destroy; to suggest is to create.” I was very much moved by that when I first read it, but my own belief is to name and to name and to name—and to name in such a way that you have rhythm, since music (and I think George Oppen

would agree with me) is also part of the meaning. If you try, for example, as I have done, to express what you see from the roof of a building—chimneys and so on—the rhythm should convey your sense of depression without your saying, “What a horrible sight!”

I suppose you could ask me why one writes this way in the first place. Why do you write in the rhythms you do? How do you get to the feeling? I’d like to read from something I’ve written down; is that all right?

Q. Certainly. Go right ahead.

A. I have written here that first there is the need, the desire, the necessity of doing it; then the way, which you find out for yourself after, perhaps, a lot of experimenting; then you give it a name, the name, and then you come to, let’s say, a formula. When I was twenty-one, I was particularly impressed by the new kind of poetry being written by Ezra Pound, H. D., and others, with sources in French free verse. It seemed to me just right, not cut to patterns, however cleverly, nor poured into ready molds—that sounds like an echo of Pound—but words and phrases flowing as the thought; to be read just like common speech—that sounds like Whitman—but for stopping at the end of each line: and this like a rest in music or a turn in the dance. I found it no criticism that to read such verse as prose was to have a kind of prose, for that was not to read it as it was written.

Q. Could we go back for a few moments to the object itself? Wouldn’t you say that the objectivist poet has a certain subjective response to a thing and tries to portray his feeling, or else he simply tries to depict an object as it is? In any case, he’s not a symbolist.

A. I see something and it moves me and I put it down as I see it. In the treatment of it, I abstain from comment. Now, if I’ve done something that moves me—if I’ve portrayed the object well—somebody will come along and also be moved, and somebody else will come along and say, “What the devil is this?” And maybe they’re both right. But what I’ve written here will perhaps answer your question more directly. “By the term ‘objectivist’ I suppose a writer may be meant who does not write directly about his feelings but about what he sees and hears; who is restricted almost to the testimony of a witness in a court of law; and who expresses his feelings indirectly by the selection of his subject-matter and, if he writes in verse, by its music.” Now suppose in a court of law, you are testifying in a negli-

gence case. You cannot get up on the stand and say, “The man was negligent.” That’s a conclusion of fact. What you’d be compelled to say is how the man acted. Did he stop before he crossed the street? Did he look? The judges of whether he is negligent or not are the jury in that case and the judges of what you say as a poet are the readers. That is, there is an analogy between testimony in the courts and the testimony of a poet.

Q. Well, exactly what are you testifying to as a poet—the world or your own feelings or both?

A. The world is very large, I think, and I certainly can’t testify to the whole of it. I can only testify to my own feelings; I can only say what I saw and heard, and I try to say it as well as I can. And if your conclusion is that what I saw and heard makes you feel the way I did, then the poem is successful.

Q. Well, I was thinking of a particular example, a very moving poem. It’s number thirteen in “Autobiography: Hollywood” [*By the Waters of Manhattan*, p. 71]. The poet observes a swarm of flies around him as though he were a shepherd watching his sheep. When only one fly is left, he still counts his blessings, and the poem concludes with the lines, “I, too, am learning how to be silent,/and have learnt long ago how to be alone.” The whole poem crystallizes here as the vision of a lonely man—only a lonely man could look at flies the way he did.

A. All right, perhaps I can tell you the origin of this poem and that will explain how I felt when I wrote it. I had a job in Hollywood at the time—a nice office, although I wasn’t doing anything nor getting anywhere. I just sat there waiting for something to do and the only thing I could notice in the office were these flies and I came to the conclusion that you see. What I was describing was exactly what “C.R.,” if I may use my initials, was experiencing, with no future that he could see and his only companions these flies. I had behind me, of course, the Bible, maybe the *Psalms*. I suppose I was thinking of “The Lord is my shepherd”; I felt myself to be something of a shepherd and it seemed to me to be amusing.

I don’t know whether it’s fair to get off on the subject of flies right now, but I found something particularly impressive in Shakespeare. In one of his early plays, *Titus Andronicus*, a man hits something and his companion asks, “What did you do?” The reply is,

“Nothing, I just killed a fly,” and his companion answers, “You killed a fly!” and has a few lines to show what a horrible thing has been done. And you feel instantly what a sensitive creature Shakespeare was. If he had written a play about Guildenstern and Rosencrantz, he would have done, of course, a much better job than what they did in New York. What a terrible thing: two young people caught up in a machine over which they have no control and crushed, as it were, as some of us would be if we were drafted for a war in which we had no interest and had to go along. Had Marlowe been handling the situation, he would have stopped with one line. It would have been a magnificent line. But Marlowe starts to write about the Jew of Malta, as you know, and his character becomes more and more comically evil. Shakespeare, on the other hand, creates a Shylock for whom we can have some sympathy.

Q. Let me get back to the flies for a moment. They seem to be concrete and symbolic at once: the destruction of a fly can be made into a symbol of one’s own condition, not just in an abstract, allegorical way, but the very feelings of killing a fly can be extended to the general feelings of being a victimizer or victim.

A. I think poetry deals essentially with feelings, the feelings of the man who writes it and the feelings of the reader, though it may fail in either direction. That perhaps is one of the distinctions between poetry and prose. The latter can be written admirably without evoking any feeling, but poetry is inherently an expression of feeling. I was impressed by Stanislavsky’s statement that art is love with technique. Once you say there’s love, you’re in the realm of feeling. Technique, of course, isn’t, but is an adjunct to express it.

Q. To go on to the historical side of my first question, I wonder whether you might speak for a while about your conversations, if any, with George Oppen and Louis Zukofsky on objectivist technique. I’d also be interested in hearing what you think about their work.

A. Well, I hate to take any aura from our talks as I remember them, if they have any to begin with, but we talked about something quite practical. We couldn’t get our poetry accepted by regular publishers, so we thought it would be nice if we organized our own publishing firm, with each of us paying for the printing of his own book. We picked the name “Objectivist” because we had all read *Poetry of Chicago* and we agreed completely with all that Pound was saying. We

didn't really discuss the term itself; it seemed all right—pregnant. It could have meant any number of things. But the mere fact that we didn't discuss its meaning doesn't deprive it of its validity.

Q. Where did Williams fit in?

A. He was a friend of Zukofsky, and Zukofsky said he was the first we ought to publish. I had seen some of Williams' verse in *Poetry* and Harriet Monroe's anthology, but I hardly knew him. Anyway, we published his first book, I believe. Zukofsky was right, not only from a critical or poetic point of view but from a practical one: the book, to my surprise, was reviewed on the second page of *The New York Times Book Review* and the edition of five hundred copies almost sold out.

Q. Was there anything similar in the approaches that you, Oppen, and Zukofsky were taking?

A. I think we all agreed that the term "objectivism," as we understood Pound's use of it, corresponded to the way we felt poetry should be written. And that included Williams, too. What we were reacting from was Tennyson. We were anti-Tennysonian. His kind of poetry didn't represent the world we knew—the streets of New York or of East Rutherford or Paterson. It might have represented the idyllic countryside where Tennyson lived, I don't doubt, or the world in which Swinburne lived—that semi-classical world. We recognized its validity; I'm sure we all felt how good were things like "the hounds of spring are on winter's traces" or the beginning of "The Lotos-Eaters." Some of it was magnificent, but it wasn't us. And certainly what was not us was the kind of poetry Austin Dobson was writing.

Q. What did you think of Zukofsky's essay on objectivism in the February 1931 issue of *Poetry*? Didn't he talk about "sincerity" and "objectification," and didn't he devote a good part of the piece to your poetry?

A. I was not displeased, of course, but I confess that I could not follow all that Zukofsky had to say about "objectification" or, for that matter, "sincerity." That may have been my fault, certainly, and I might have kept on trying. I remember that Pound praised him.

Q. Well, Zukofsky can be very difficult to understand, both in poetry and prose.

A. To me the use of language means communication. If you write, you write to be understood, and if you're not understood, you've failed. I'm a great believer in clarity and I try to practice it; that's why I'm interested in precision in the use of words, which is a part of clarity. I think the only importance in writing is to convey meaning or emotion.

Incidentally, speaking of technique, I came across an interesting statement in *The New York Review of Books* some time ago. The reviewer, commenting on translations of Sappho, said this: "At her most intense, she writes the kind of poetry that Stevens dreamed of, a poetry that 'without evasion by a single metaphor' sees 'the very thing itself and nothing else.' English poetry is in this special sense incurably evasive and requires a richer medium to achieve equally powerful effects." I'm not so sure that English poetry needs the use of metaphor, as this reviewer suggests, despite all the magnificent examples we have of it. But the difficulty in talking about Greek poets like Sappho or Archilochus is that we only have fragments in most cases. Now, there's a magnificent fragment by Archilochus in which there is simply a description of a girl walking, with her hair about her shoulders. I wouldn't want to see her compared to a hind or whatever. I think that frequently images cloud understanding rather than illuminate it. Of course, I use images too. If something good comes along, fine. But I still think that reviewer's statement was pertinent.

Q. Well, perhaps we can talk specifically about your own poetry. Much of your earlier and some of your later work seems to contain a *haikuesque* simplicity and turn of thought. For example—just one out of many—is the little poem that reads, "What are you doing in our street among the automobiles,/horse?/How are your cousins, the centaur and the unicorn?" [*By the Waters of Manhattan*, p. 25]. It says a great deal about the sensibility of the speaker, who looks upon a horse as being so unusual that it has become a fabulous creature.

A. That's just what I intended. A Japanese boy came up to me once, after a reading that included that poem, and asked me what the last line was doing there. He would have left it out. After reading a lot of *haiku*, I realized that's exactly the way they're written in Japan. Most of them seemed to be just a simple statement that is expected to suggest a particular mood or feeling. But if I had left the last line out, my whole meaning would have been lost.

I may add this about my writing that kind of poem: I showed a

friend who had been studying Shakespeare with Kittredge at Harvard two of my pieces that Harriet Monroe had accepted for Poetry. He began to read them the way Kittredge read Shakespeare, analyzing every word in minute detail. He tore my verse apart, and his comments were hardly complimentary. I was enormously gratified. I had just spent four years studying law, reading cases closely for the meaning of every word, and had thought those years completely wasted. And here I suddenly saw that all this machinery that I thought had to be junked was actually useful. I could analyze my poems as my friend did, in my own way, and I was often left with two or three lines. The rest seemed, by Kittredge's standards, negligible or superfluous; three or so lines—if that many—were all that had to be said. I suppose that's the way I reached the *haiku* style.

Q. I think it's really your medium and I'm happy Kittredge influenced you. I'd like to go on, if we can, to your poems on Jewish themes. These poems seem to emphasize the endurance of the Jews as a people, and yet the poet is alienated from Jewish traditions. I'm thinking in particular of the poem in which you write, "My parents were of a great company/that went together, hand in hand;/but I must make my way alone/over waves and barren land" [BWM, p. 106]. And the poem called "Russia: Anno 1905" [BWM, p. 36] seems to sum up the dilemma of the modern Jew.

A. Perhaps it represents a situation that is—and has been—common among Jews. Even in early times, many Jews were attracted to cultures they thought to be superior, like Hellenism. I was only expressing the way I felt. But one changes as one grows older and sees more reason for ritual—more value in it. I wasn't taught any Hebrew at all; I began picking it up in my thirties. The tendency is, on the one hand, to be assimilated and, on the other, to be yourself. Some people accentuate one or the other, but assimilation has historically been common among Jews. It's in one's nature to become part of the surrounding community.

Q. But in your poems assimilation does not seem to be the primary theme. There's a poem in *Jerusalem the Golden* that reads in part, "I have married and married the speech of strangers;/none are like you, Shulamite" [BWM, p. 19]. There seems to be a personal sense of isolation or exile here.

A. I don't think "isolation" is the word. I don't feel isolated in Eng-

lish; it's just that I'm missing a lot in not knowing Hebrew. Incidentally, Havelock Ellis in one of his books, as I remember it, points out the tendency in a writer to use characteristics of the speech of his ancestors, even a speech he no longer knows. For example, Ellis says that Addison ends sentences with a preposition, although this is not usual in English, because Addison was of Danish stock and the Danes end sentences with prepositions. This is only one of his examples among a number. I don't know how sound all this is but it may be worth going into.

Speaking of Jewish endurance, one of the poems I like is based on a situation that occurred when I was in high school. There was a boy in my class from Persia—an Aryan if there ever was one—but the non-Jews would have nothing to do with him and he would have nothing to do with the Jews. He was completely isolated and eventually, I was told, committed suicide. That greatly impressed me. In that poem I have it that Jews don't find such isolation poison.

Q. "Scorn/shall be your meat/instead of praise;/you shall eat and eat of it/all your days,/and grow strong on it . . . Jew" ["Glosses," *BWM*, p. 55].

A. "And live long on it."

Q. In any case, it seems that the true values in your poetry are sensitivity and an inner spiritual strength. And these values seem to be prevalent in your verse plays as well. It doesn't matter who the people are, their strength against an antagonistic society makes them the heroes or martyrs they become.

A. They question. Let me refer to *The Apocalyptic Ezra* [*BWM*, p. 94]. Ezra is a minor Job. His position is this: "Look, why is Babylon treated so well? Are they so good?" And the angel replies by asking him questions like, can he weigh fire or measure the wind? If he can't do even these things, how can he expect to know the ways of God? The theme is the limitation of human knowledge. Actually the work was stimulated by the treatment of the Jews under the Romans.

Q. One has the feeling in your poetry that Judaism is a state of mind rather than a faith.

A. I think it's a kind of discipline too. One may not accept all aspects of that discipline, but the one he must accept is that he be himself, although he may conform to his environment in minor ways. These are the Jews who survive as Jews.

Q. Survive spiritually, though they might eventually lose their lives, as does Miriamne in your verse play, *Captive Israel*.

A. I must confess that many of those plays began with my irritation with the current theater. Uriel Acosta started with my dissatisfaction with a German play by that name. It was very romantic; the hero wasn't bothered by any theological questions except incidentally—he was in love. That explained all his troubles. As for *Captive Israel*, there was a play, written by an Englishman on the same subject, that bothered me; so I went back to Josephus. What actually happened was this: Miriamne was married to Herod, who was apparently a professing Jew but also a tool of Rome. He married Miriamne because she represented the ancient royal family. Like any other politician of his time, he used assassination to get rid of her brother, who was the legitimate heir to the throne.

Q. But the point of the play really seemed to concern Miriamne and what she endured simply by being true to her principles—by not conforming.

A. Of course, I felt sympathetic toward her. But let me say this about the plays: they are really libretti and should be accompanied by music. They really require staging and dancing. When I wrote them, I was very much under the influence of German expressionist drama, particularly that of Georg Kaiser. I was also interested in *The Dybbuk*, which had a lot of music and dancing.

Q. Then your verse plays were meant to be performed?

A. Yes, but they never were and probably never will be.

Q. Well, I was much interested in the mode in which these plays were presented. The scenes were presented almost “imagistically,” without any transitions between them.

A. That's true. That's the expressionist influence. In one of Kaiser's best plays, as I recall, a bank clerk throws up his job and goes through one experience after another. There's really no relation among them except that the man is trying to find himself. I think what I did in the plays is exactly what I tried to do in my other verse: cut out everything that wasn't interesting in the hope that what was left would be.

Q. So you were writing *haikuesque* plays as well as poems.

A. Yes, I think one does the same thing over and over again.

Q. Well, that brings us to the question of *Testimony: The United States, 1885–1890*, a work that doesn't seem at all to be in the mainstream of your poetry.

A. *Testimony* may be explained by T. S. Eliot's "objective correlative," as I understand it. Something happens and it expresses something that you feel, not necessarily because of those facts, but because of entirely different facts that give you the same kind of feeling. Now, in reading law, if the cases state any facts, they're just a sentence or two; but, occasionally, you'll find the facts gone into in detail, sometimes to explain or defend the judge's position. Still the facts have a function of their own—psychological, sociological, and perhaps even poetical. In *Testimony* the speakers whose words I use are all giving testimony about what they actually lived through. The testimony is that of a witness in court—not a statement of what he felt, but of what he saw or heard. What I wanted to do was to create by selection, arrangement, and the rhythm of the words used as a mood or feeling. I could have picked any period because the same thing is happening today that was happening in 1885. For example, in the volume I'm working on now there's a description of a Negro riot in St. Louis around 1900. A reviewer wrote that when he read *Testimony* a second time he saw a world of horror and violence. I didn't invent the world, but I felt it.

Q. But doesn't testimony as such come out as simply a transcription of reality?

A. But I throw out an awful lot to achieve my purpose. It's not a complete picture of the United States at any time, by any means. It's only a part of what happened, a reality that I felt as a reader and could not portray adequately in any other way. But I will tell you, if it's any satisfaction, that *Testimony* had very little sale.

Q. Well, that's certainly no satisfaction.

A. This discussion about testimony and events being lived through brings me to a warning I'd like to make. I suppose I'm an "objectivist" and I have my own "formula" for writing, but no formula can be a guarantee of good writing. I think behind any poem there's a background of experience and emotion that explains its moving quality. Sometimes even the poet himself may have forgotten the background. It's a mystery.

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